CATEGORY WINNERS **HEALTH**

A CLEAN BILL OF HEALTH

The southern states of Puducherry and Kerala tick all the right boxes in health. Himachal Pradesh and Mizoram show promise too



MAKING STRIDES
Puducherry CM N. Rangasamy

ANI



With the highest per capita health expenditure of Rs 9,871 in 2021-22, more than thrice the national average of just over Rs 3,000, and a well-structured healthcare network, Kerala has emerged as the best performing big state in health for the third consecutive year. Puducherry, meanwhile, continues to be the best performing small state. When it comes to states that have shown most improvement in the past five years, Himachal Pradesh and Mizoram grab the honours among the big and small states, respectively. Other than expenditure on health per person, these states were evaluated on parameters such as the infant mortality rate (IMR), maternal mortality rate (MMR), registered doctors and government hospitals per lakh persons, average patients served and number of beds per government hospital, and life expectancy.

Best Performing Big State: Kerala

Kerala leads in various health parameters in the country, a feat made possible by the wide network of 1,284 government health institutions and an army of 6,355 government doctors and 21,421 paramedical staff. Also known for the lowest IMR (6 per 1,000 live births) and MMR (30 per 100,000 live births), Kerala records just 0.1 per cent live births without the medical attention of qualified professionals, against the national average of 7.8. The southern state also managed the Covid-19 pandemic with effective intervention. "We are committed to deliver best healthcare to the people and are making all attempts to expand our services," says Kerala health minister Veena George. "Since Kerala is facing a major challenge in dealing with post-Covid complications, we have started specialty clinics and made a huge investment in modernising operation theatres and surgery wards."

Best Performing Small State: Puducherry

Providing healthcare for the four geographically distant districts of Puducherry is a logistical challenge. Yet, its people have accessible medical care within an average distance of 1.18 kilometres through a network of primary health centres, sub centres, and disease-specific clinics in addition to eight hospitals. Exceptional community-wide disease management and consistent supply of medicines have been made possible by a rising budgetary allocation for health—from Rs 724 crore in 2021-22 to Rs 1,020 crore in 2022-23, about 9.5 per cent of the total outlay. "We aim to set up a medical university. We want Puducherry to emerges as a model state in [medical] education," says Chief Minister N. Rangasamy.

SPECIALTY CLINICS ARE HELPING KERALA DEAL WITH POST-COVID COMPLICATIONS